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1. Why is patriarchy a classical phenomenon in Bangladesh? Explain what are the indicators of outlier of Bangladesh and why they exist?

2. Why are there changes in the Agency although no revolutionary changes are seen?

Answer 1: Patriarchy as a Classical Phenomenon & Bangladesh as an Outlier

Patriarchy in Bangladesh is considered a **classical phenomenon** because it shares the structural features of the “belt of classic patriarchy” identified in South Asia and the Middle East. These include **patrilineal inheritance, patrilocal residence, male dominance, restricted female mobility, and strong son preference**. Women’s security traditionally depends on sons, which leads to **high fertility and gender discrimination**, reinforcing patriarchal norms. Such structures historically limited women’s agency and economic participation.

However, Bangladesh is identified as a “**positive outlier**” because it achieved significant social progress despite these constraints. Indicators of this outlier status include:

1. **Economic dimension:** Improved health, education, and gender equality despite low per capita GDP.
2. **Political dimension:** Social progress despite weak governance, corruption, and clientelism.
3. **Cultural dimension:** Advancements in women’s status despite conservative religious influences.

Additional empirical indicators include **declining fertility, improved life expectancy, reduced infant mortality, and disappearance of gender gaps in child mortality**. Unlike India, Bangladesh did not adopt sex-selective abortion, maintaining a **balanced sex ratio**.

These outcomes exist due to **policy support, NGO-state collaboration, and expansion of women’s economic roles**, which enhanced women’s agency. Thus, while patriarchy remains structurally embedded, Bangladesh’s development trajectory challenges conventional theories by demonstrating that **social progress can occur within, not after, patriarchy**.

Answer 2: Change in Agency without Revolutionary Transformation

Changes in women’s agency in Bangladesh have occurred **without revolutionary or abrupt transformation** because they are embedded within existing patriarchal structures rather than replacing them. The process is best understood as **incremental and negotiated change**, not structural rupture.

The evidence shows that women increasingly participate in decision-making, education, and economic activities. They **make fertility decisions, invest in children, and engage in paid work**, which gradually enhances their bargaining power within households. This improves their influence over resource allocation and reduces discrimination against daughters.

However, these changes occur through “**patriarchal bargains**”, where women do not directly challenge patriarchy but **negotiate within its constraints** for better outcomes. For example, earlier strategies emphasized son preference for security, but with new opportunities (education, employment), dependence on sons declines and gender norms gradually shift.

The key reason for non-revolutionary change is that **social norms, kinship systems, and cultural practices remain intact**, shaping the limits of agency. As noted, “structures shape women’s choices, but do not fully determine them”. Therefore, women exercise agency **within boundaries**, leading to gradual transformation in gender relations, fertility behavior, and social attitudes.

Thus, agency evolves through **cumulative everyday actions**, producing significant outcomes (e.g., fertility decline, improved gender equality) without dismantling patriarchy. This explains why Bangladesh's transformation is **evolutionary rather than revolutionary**.

Question: Venezuela is not just an economic collapse, it is a lesson on governance and diversification.

Venezuela's economic collapse is often described as one of the worst in modern history, but it is more than just an economic failure—it is a clear lesson about the importance of governance and economic diversification. Once considered one of the richest countries in Latin America, Venezuela built its prosperity on vast oil reserves. The discovery of oil in the early 20th century transformed the economy and made petroleum the dominant source of national income. Oil was nationalized in 1976 and became the backbone of the economy, leading to heavy dependence on a single sector. While this brought short-term wealth, it created long-term vulnerability. Instead of using oil revenue to develop other sectors such as agriculture, manufacturing, or technology, the country remained overly reliant on oil exports. This lack of diversification meant that when global oil prices fell—especially after 2014—the entire economy was severely affected. Government revenues declined sharply, imports became difficult, and economic stability quickly collapsed.

However, the crisis cannot be explained by oil dependence alone; governance failures played an even more critical role. Over time, Venezuela experienced weak institutions, corruption, and poor economic management. Governments relied heavily on oil income to fund public spending, often without proper planning or savings for the future. Policies such as price controls, excessive nationalization, and over-regulation discouraged private investment and reduced productivity. During the leadership of Hugo Chávez and later Nicolás Maduro, social welfare programs expanded, but they were largely funded by oil revenue rather than sustainable economic growth. When oil income declined, the government struggled to maintain these programs and began printing money to cover deficits, leading to hyperinflation. As a result, the value of the national currency collapsed, prices skyrocketed, and basic goods like food and medicine became scarce. Political instability also increased, with growing tensions between the government and opposition, further weakening economic confidence and governance structures. This shows that even with abundant natural resources, poor governance can lead to economic disaster.

The combined effect of weak governance and lack of diversification turned Venezuela's economic crisis into a broader social and humanitarian crisis. Millions of people faced unemployment, poverty, and shortages of essential goods, forcing many to migrate to other countries in search of better opportunities. What makes Venezuela's case particularly important is that it demonstrates the concept of the "resource curse"—where countries rich in natural resources fail to achieve sustainable development due to mismanagement and overdependence. The lesson for students and policymakers is very clear: natural resources alone cannot guarantee prosperity. A stable and transparent system of governance is necessary to manage resources effectively, while diversification of the economy helps protect against external shocks such as price fluctuations in global markets. In conclusion, Venezuela is not just an example of economic collapse; it is a powerful warning. It teaches that long-term development depends on strong institutions, responsible leadership, and a balanced economic structure. Without these, even the wealthiest nations can fall into crisis.